

Executive Summary

Project Hope Food Bank of Lynden provides an important service to the local community, and I am grateful for the support they provide to people who need help, including those living on a fixed income.

After speaking with the team, I understand that Project Hope currently uses Excel spreadsheets to manage inventory and related operational information. While spreadsheets are useful and familiar, they can become difficult to maintain as inventory changes, donations come in, food is distributed, and multiple people need accurate information.

Since Project Hope has asked me to look at their current systems, I would like to volunteer my technical experience to help evaluate whether a better, low-cost solution could support their work. The goal would not be to introduce unnecessary complexity or expensive software. Instead, the goal would be to understand how the food bank currently operates and identify practical ways to make the process easier, more accurate, and more sustainable.

Because budget is an important concern, any proposed solution should emphasize free or open-source software where possible, donated volunteer development time, and storage or hosting options that keep ongoing costs as low as reasonably possible.

At a high level, a future system could help Project Hope track incoming donations, current inventory, food distribution, expiration dates, reporting needs, and other day-to-day information. A better system could reduce manual effort, improve accuracy, help prevent waste, and make it easier for staff and volunteers to understand what food is available and what items are most needed.

The recommended first step is a simple discovery phase. This would involve reviewing the current spreadsheets, understanding the existing workflow, identifying pain points, and learning what the staff and volunteers actually need. From there, a small prototype or phased improvement plan could be developed before making any major changes.

The overall objective is to help Project Hope Food Bank of Lynden improve its inventory and operational tracking in a practical, affordable, and maintainable way that supports the people already doing the work.